



POLAND

Capital city: Warsaw
Area: 120,728 sq miles (312,685 sq km)
Population: 38,600,000
Official language: Polish
Major religions: Christian 95%, other 5%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Zloty
Adult literacy rate: 99%
Life expectancy: 74 years
People per doctor: 455
Televisions: 413 per 1,000 people

POLAND

POLAND IS A MIX OF SCATTERED farming villages and magnificent medieval towns. This mainly flat country is larger than the other three countries of Central Europe put together. Once a land of many different peoples, warfare, migration, and border changes in 1945 have made the majority of people now Polish-speaking Roman Catholics. During the 1980s, Poland broke free from Soviet communist control and began the difficult journey toward a more democratic political system.



Market in Warsaw

HEAVY INDUSTRY

Under the former Soviet Union, Poland was part of a vast centralized economy. For example, iron would be shipped into Poland, where it was then made into goods such as tractors for export to other parts of the Soviet Union. However, with the arrival of democracy, the country has attempted to find new markets for its goods in the West and Germany is now its main trading partner.

Painted wooden eggs are exchanged at Easter.

Wooden box carved with a traditional pattern



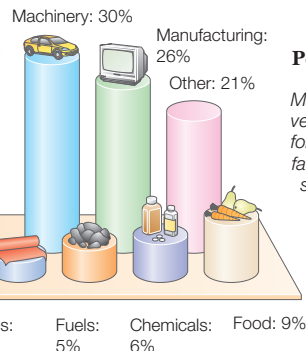
A TRADITIONAL WAY OF LIFE

This nation of small-scale farmers clung fiercely to its local traditions throughout the years of Soviet control. As a result, unlike other countries under Soviet rule, the many small farms were not merged into larger state-run farms. Today, traditions such as horse-drawn plowing are still common in parts of Poland. Local folk arts and crafts flourish, too. Embroidery and woodcarving are often used to decorate household objects, and wooden furniture may be colorfully painted.



DEVELOPING INDUSTRIES

Poland is making the transition from a planned, communist-style economy to a free market. It no longer relies on heavy industry such as shipbuilding and coal mining, but is starting to develop industries such as tourism (above) and electronics. A "shock therapy" program during the early 1990s helped the country transform its economy into one of the strongest in Central Europe. Poland joined the NATO alliance in 1999 and the European union in 2004.



Polish exports

Major exports include vehicles, machinery for industry and farming, and crops such as potatoes and other vegetables. Poland is also a major world exporter of coal and metals.



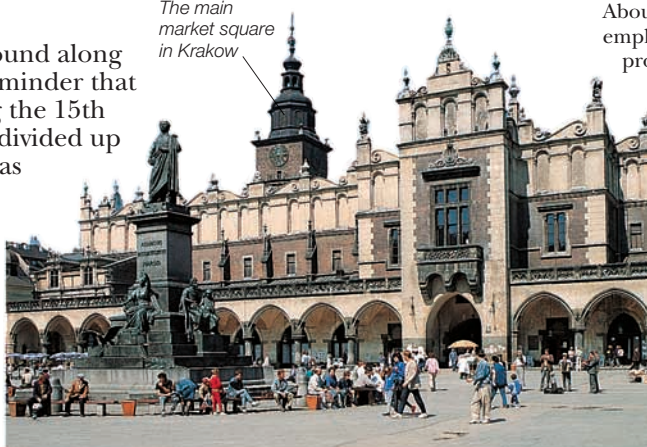
AGRICULTURE

About a quarter of the nation's workforce is employed in agriculture. The most important products are potatoes, sugar beets, cereals, and livestock. Some farms specialize in commercial crops, but most grow some crops for selling and some for feeding the family. This is partly because most farms are still small and privately owned, often operated part-time, frequently by elderly or retired owners.

MEDIEVAL KRAKOW

The superb medieval buildings found along the city streets of Krakow are a reminder that Poland was a major power during the 15th and 16th centuries, before it was divided up among other countries. Poland has some of the finest old churches, palaces, and public buildings in Europe. Many were destroyed or damaged during World War II, but Krakow's buildings escaped relatively unscathed. Unfortunately, this is also one of the most air-polluted cities in Europe, due mainly to the nearby Nowa Huta Steelworks.

The main market square in Krakow



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